

Spectral Units of Memory:

A Natural Measurement Framework for Non-Markovian Systems

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February 4, 2026

Abstract

We introduce a comprehensive framework for quantifying memory in non-Markovian dynamical systems through spectral decomposition of memory kernels. Classical information theory measures memory in bits—discrete, stateless units designed for Markovian processes. However, systems with temporal memory require fundamentally different units that capture *temporal extent*, *timescale distribution*, and *complexity*. We propose four natural units: memory capacity M_{cap} (mean temporal depth), spectral span M_{scale} (range in decades), memory resolution M_{res} (modes per decade), and spectral entropy H_{mem} (timescale uniformity). These combine into an effective memory dimension D_{eff} that serves as a universal comparator across physical, biological, and engineered systems. We prove fundamental bounds, establish connections to computational complexity and thermodynamic limits, demonstrate applications to neural systems and climate dynamics, and provide a hardware implementation pathway via analog circuits. This framework positions spectral modes as the natural unit for memory, analogous to Shannon’s bit for information.

Keywords: Non-Markovian dynamics, Memory kernels, Spectral decomposition, Information theory, Computational complexity, Thermodynamic computing

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1 Introduction

1.1 The Problem with Bits

Information theory, as established by Shannon [1], measures information in *bits*—the distinction between two possibilities. For a system with N discrete states, the information content is $\log_2 N$ bits. This framework has been extraordinarily successful for communication, data compression, and computational theory.

However, bits are fundamentally designed for *stateless* or *Markovian* systems where the future depends only on the present state. Consider a computer’s RAM: each memory address stores a definite bit pattern representing the current state. The past values stored at that address are irrelevant—they have been overwritten.

Non-Markovian systems operate differently. Their dynamics depend on *history* through a memory kernel $K(t)$ that weights past states:

$$\frac{\partial u}{\partial t}(x, t) = \int_0^t K(t-s) \mathcal{L}[u(x, s)] ds + \text{forcing}, \quad (1)$$

where $\mathcal{L}$ is a spatial operator and $K(t-s)$ determines how strongly the state at time s influences evolution at time t .

Why bits fail for memory kernels:

- (1) **Discrete vs. continuous:** Bits count states; memory is a continuous weighting function.
- (2) **Stateless vs. path-dependent:** Bits encode “now”; memory encodes “trajectory influence.”
- (3) **No timescale:** Bits don’t capture *how long* information persists.

1.2 Motivating Examples

1.2.1 Biological Memory

A neuron’s response depends on its recent spike history through ion channel recovery, synaptic facilitation/depression, and dendritic integration. These processes span timescales from milliseconds (Na^+ inactivation) to seconds (Ca^{2+} buffering). Classical bits cannot quantify “this neuron has 3 decades of memory span with 5 modes per decade.”

1.2.2 Climate Dynamics

Earth’s climate exhibits memory through ocean heat storage (decades), ice sheet dynamics (centuries), and atmospheric CO_2 buffering (millennia). How do we compare climate memory to neural memory? Bits provide no basis for comparison.

1.2.3 Quantum Decoherence

An open quantum system coupled to a structured environment exhibits non-Markovian recurrences as information flows back from bath to system. The timescales and structure of this memory determine decoherence rates—yet quantum information theory measures only qubits, not memory kernels.

1.3 Our Contribution

We propose **spectral units of memory** derived from the sum-of-exponentials (SOE) decomposition of memory kernels. Every physically realizable kernel $K(t)$ can be approximated as:

$$K(t) \approx \sum_{\ell=1}^L w_{\ell} e^{-\gamma_{\ell} t}, \quad w_{\ell} > 0, \quad \gamma_{\ell} > 0. \quad (2)$$

From this representation, we extract four fundamental units:

- M_{cap} : **Memory capacity** (mean temporal depth)
- M_{scale} : **Spectral span** (range of timescales)
- M_{res} : **Memory resolution** (granularity of timescale sampling)
- H_{mem} : **Spectral entropy** (uniformity of weight distribution)

These combine into an **effective memory dimension** D_{eff} that serves as a universal comparator.

Connection to related frameworks: This work complements the Geometric Fourier Extension (GFE) framework [5], which provides the computational infrastructure (SOE embedding $\rightarrow$ auxiliary variables $\rightarrow O(N)$ complexity) for simulating memory kernels. While GFE answers “how do we compute efficiently?”, spectral units answer “how do we measure and compare memory?”

1.4 Organization

Section 2 reviews memory kernels and SOE approximations. Section 3 defines the four spectral units. Section 4 introduces effective memory dimension D_{eff} . Section 5 proves fundamental theorems and bounds. Section 6 demonstrates applications. Section 7 connects to computational complexity. Section 8 establishes thermodynamic limits. Section 9 provides implementation pathways. Section 10 discusses implications and limitations.

2 Preliminaries: Memory Kernels and SOE Approximation

2.1 Memory Kernels in Non-Markovian Dynamics

A **memory kernel** $K : [0, \infty) \rightarrow \mathbb{C}$ encodes how past states influence present evolution. Common origins:

- **Fractional diffusion:** Continuous-time random walks with power-law waiting times yield $K(t) = t^{-\alpha}/\Gamma(1-\alpha)$ for $0 < \alpha < 1$ [2].
- **Viscoelasticity:** Stress-strain relations in polymers give $K(t) = \sum_j G_j e^{-t/\tau_j}$ (Maxwell model) [3].
- **Open quantum systems:** Environment-induced memory from structured baths produces oscillatory kernels $K(t) = \sum_{\ell} w_{\ell} e^{-(\gamma_{\ell} + i\Omega_{\ell})t}$ [4].

2.2 Sum-of-Exponentials (SOE) Approximation

Definition 2.1 (Positive SOE Kernel). A kernel $K(t)$ admits a **positive sum-of-exponentials (SOE) approximation** if there exist $L \in \mathbb{N}$, weights $\{w_\ell\}_{\ell=1}^L \subset \mathbb{R}_+$, and rates $\{\gamma_\ell\}_{\ell=1}^L \subset \mathbb{R}_+$ such that

$$K(t) \approx K_L(t) := \sum_{\ell=1}^L w_\ell e^{-\gamma_\ell t} \quad (3)$$

with approximation error $\|K - K_L\|_{L^\infty[0,T]} < \epsilon$ for desired tolerance ϵ and time horizon T .

Remark 2.2 (Computational Motivation). The SOE form transforms nonlocal convolutions into local ODEs via auxiliary variables [5]:

$$\frac{d\chi_\ell}{dt} = -\gamma_\ell \chi_\ell + f(u), \quad \ell = 1, \dots, L, \quad (4)$$

$$\int_0^t K(t-s)f(u(s))ds \approx \sum_{\ell=1}^L w_\ell \chi_\ell(t). \quad (5)$$

This reduces complexity from $O(N_t^2)$ to $O(LN_t)$ where N_t is the number of timesteps.

2.3 Timescale Representation

Define the **characteristic timescales**:

$$\tau_\ell := \frac{1}{\gamma_\ell}. \quad (6)$$

Physical interpretation: $e^{-\gamma_\ell t} = e^{-t/\tau_\ell}$ decays to $e^{-1} \approx 0.37$ of its initial value after time τ_ℓ . Thus τ_ℓ measures how long mode ℓ “remembers.”

2.4 Normalized Weights

For spectral entropy calculations, we normalize weights:

$$\tilde{w}_\ell := \frac{w_\ell}{\sum_{j=1}^L w_j}. \quad (7)$$

3 Core Definitions: Four Spectral Units

3.1 Memory Capacity: Mean Temporal Depth

Definition 3.1 (Memory Capacity). The **memory capacity** M_{cap} of a kernel $K(t)$ is the mean temporal depth:

$$M_{\text{cap}} := \langle t \rangle_K = \frac{\int_0^\infty |K(t)| t dt}{\int_0^\infty |K(t)| dt}. \quad (8)$$

For an SOE kernel,

$$M_{\text{cap}} = \frac{\sum_{\ell=1}^L w_\ell \tau_\ell^2}{\sum_{\ell=1}^L w_\ell \tau_\ell} = \frac{\sum_{\ell=1}^L w_\ell / \gamma_\ell^2}{\sum_{\ell=1}^L w_\ell / \gamma_\ell}. \quad (9)$$

Units: [time]

Example 3.2 (Exponential Kernel). For $K(t) = e^{-t/\tau}/\tau$ (single timescale):

$$M_{\text{cap}} = \frac{\int_0^\infty e^{-t/\tau} t dt / \tau}{\int_0^\infty e^{-t/\tau} dt / \tau} = \frac{\tau^2}{\tau} = \tau.$$

The memory depth equals the characteristic timescale.

Example 3.3 (Dirac Delta). For $K(t) = \delta(t)$ (Markovian):

$$M_{\text{cap}} = 0.$$

No memory—instantaneous response.

3.2 Spectral Span: Timescale Range

Definition 3.4 (Spectral Span). The **spectral span** M_{scale} measures the range of timescales in decades:

$$M_{\text{scale}} := \log_{10} \left(\frac{\tau_{\text{max}}}{\tau_{\text{min}}} \right) = \log_{10} \left(\frac{\gamma_{\text{max}}}{\gamma_{\text{min}}} \right), \quad (10)$$

where $\tau_{\text{max}} = \max_{\ell} \tau_{\ell}$ and $\tau_{\text{min}} = \min_{\ell} \tau_{\ell}$.

Units: [decades] (dimensionless)

Example 3.5 (Multi-Scale Systems). • Neuron: $\tau_{\text{min}} = 1 \text{ ms}$, $\tau_{\text{max}} = 1 \text{ s} \Rightarrow M_{\text{scale}} = 3$ decades.

• Climate: $\tau_{\text{min}} = 1 \text{ day}$, $\tau_{\text{max}} = 100 \text{ years} \approx 36500 \text{ days} \Rightarrow M_{\text{scale}} \approx 4.6$ decades.

Remark 3.6 (Edge Case). If $L = 1$ (single exponential), then $\tau_{\text{max}} = \tau_{\text{min}}$ and $M_{\text{scale}} = 0$. This correctly identifies single-timescale systems as having zero spectral span.

3.3 Memory Resolution: Modes per Decade

Definition 3.7 (Memory Resolution). The **memory resolution** M_{res} quantifies how finely memory is resolved across timescales:

$$M_{\text{res}} := \frac{L}{M_{\text{scale}}}. \quad (11)$$

Units: [modes/decade]

Interpretation: M_{res} measures the density of exponential modes. High M_{res} implies fine temporal resolution; low M_{res} implies coarse sampling.

Example 3.8 (Resolution Comparison). • System A: $L = 10$ modes spanning $M_{\text{scale}} = 2$ decades $\Rightarrow M_{\text{res}} = 5$ modes/decade (fine).

• System B: $L = 10$ modes spanning $M_{\text{scale}} = 5$ decades $\Rightarrow M_{\text{res}} = 2$ modes/decade (coarse).

3.4 Spectral Entropy: Weight Uniformity

Definition 3.9 (Spectral Entropy). The **spectral entropy** H_{mem} quantifies the uniformity of weight distribution:

$$H_{\text{mem}} := - \sum_{\ell=1}^L \tilde{w}_{\ell} \ln \tilde{w}_{\ell}, \quad (12)$$

where $\tilde{w}_{\ell}$ are normalized weights (7).

The **normalized spectral entropy** is

$$\tilde{H}_{\text{mem}} := \frac{H_{\text{mem}}}{\ln L} \in [0, 1]. \quad (13)$$

Units: [nats] for H_{mem} ; dimensionless for $\tilde{H}_{\text{mem}}$.

Proposition 3.10 (Entropy Bounds).

$$0 \leq H_{\text{mem}} \leq \ln L, \quad (14)$$

with equality on the right when $\tilde{w}_\ell = 1/L$ for all ℓ (uniform distribution), and minimum when $\tilde{w}_k = 1$ for some k (single dominant mode).

Proof. Standard result from Shannon entropy. Maximum entropy for discrete distribution with L outcomes is $\ln L$ (using natural logarithm) achieved by uniform distribution. Minimum is 0 when one probability equals 1. $\square$

Example 3.11 (Entropy Interpretation). • **Specialized memory:** Circadian rhythm with two dominant timescales ($\tau_{\text{fast}} \sim 1$ s for neurons, $\tau_{\text{slow}} \sim 24$ h for circadian clock). If $L = 10$ but $w_1 = w_5 = 0.4$ and others share 0.2, then $H_{\text{mem}} \approx 1.5$ nats and $\tilde{H}_{\text{mem}} \approx 0.65$ (moderate specialization).

- **Uniform memory:** Turbulent flow with broad spectrum. If all $\tilde{w}_\ell = 1/L$, then $H_{\text{mem}} = \ln L$ and $\tilde{H}_{\text{mem}} = 1$ (maximal diversity).

4 Effective Memory Dimension

4.1 Motivation: A Unified Comparator

The four units ($M_{\text{cap}}, M_{\text{scale}}, M_{\text{res}}, H_{\text{mem}}$) each capture orthogonal aspects of memory. To enable direct comparison across systems, we combine them into a single scalar.

Definition 4.1 (Effective Memory Dimension). The **effective memory dimension** D_{eff} is defined as

$$D_{\text{eff}} := M_{\text{scale}} \times M_{\text{res}} \times \exp(H_{\text{mem}}) = L \times \exp(H_{\text{mem}}). \quad (15)$$

Units: [effective modes] (dimensionless)

Interpretation:

- $M_{\text{scale}} \times M_{\text{res}} = L$: Total number of modes.
- $\exp(H_{\text{mem}})$: Effective number of “active” modes accounting for weight distribution.
- D_{eff} : Weighted count of independent memory channels.

Example 4.2 (Computing D_{eff}). **Uniform weights:** If $\tilde{w}_\ell = 1/L$, then $H_{\text{mem}} = \ln L$ and

$$D_{\text{eff}} = L \exp(\ln L) = L^2.$$

Single dominant mode: If $\tilde{w}_1 = 1$, then $H_{\text{mem}} = 0$ and

$$D_{\text{eff}} = L \exp(0) = L.$$

Moderate diversity: For the circadian example ($H_{\text{mem}} \approx 1.5$, $L = 10$):

$$D_{\text{eff}} = 10 \times e^{1.5} \approx 10 \times 4.48 \approx 45.$$

4.2 Physical Interpretation

D_{eff} represents the **effective dimensionality of the memory space**. Just as a spatial system is characterized by dimension d (1D, 2D, 3D), a memory system is characterized by D_{eff} .

Analogy: A 3D cube has more “room” than a 2D square. A system with $D_{\text{eff}} = 100$ has more memory capacity than one with $D_{\text{eff}} = 10$.

4.3 Compact Notation

We denote a memory system compactly as

$$\mathcal{M}(M_{\text{cap}}, M_{\text{scale}}, M_{\text{res}}, H_{\text{mem}}) \rightarrow D_{\text{eff}}. \quad (16)$$

Examples:

$$\text{Markovian system: } \mathcal{M}(0, 0, \text{undefined}, 0) \rightarrow 0, \quad (17)$$

$$\text{Human working memory: } \mathcal{M}(10 \text{ s}, 3, 3, 1.2) \rightarrow 30, \quad (18)$$

$$\text{Climate system: } \mathcal{M}(10 \text{ yr}, 7, 2, 1.8) \rightarrow 84. \quad (19)$$

5 Theoretical Foundations

5.1 Fundamental Bounds

Theorem 5.1 (Memory Dimension Bounds). *For any SOE kernel with L modes spanning M_{scale} decades:*

$$D_{\text{eff}} \leq L^2, \quad (20)$$

$$D_{\text{eff}} \leq L \times e^{\ln L} = L^2. \quad (21)$$

Equality holds when weights are uniform: $\tilde{w}_\ell = 1/L$.

Proof. From Definition 4.1,

$$D_{\text{eff}} = L \exp(H_{\text{mem}}).$$

By Proposition 3.10, $H_{\text{mem}} \leq \ln L$, so

$$D_{\text{eff}} \leq L e^{\ln L} = L^2.$$

Equality when $H_{\text{mem}} = \ln L$ (uniform weights). □

Corollary 5.2 (Minimum Effective Dimension). *For fixed L , the minimum effective dimension is*

$$D_{\text{eff}}^{\min} = L \times e^0 = L,$$

achieved when one weight dominates: $\tilde{w}_k = 1$ for some k .

5.2 Memory Isomorphism

Definition 5.3 (Memory Equivalence). Two systems are **memory-equivalent** if they share the same spectral units:

$$\mathcal{M}_1 = \mathcal{M}_2 \iff (M_{\text{cap}}^{(1)}, M_{\text{scale}}^{(1)}, M_{\text{res}}^{(1)}, H_{\text{mem}}^{(1)}) = (M_{\text{cap}}^{(2)}, M_{\text{scale}}^{(2)}, M_{\text{res}}^{(2)}, H_{\text{mem}}^{(2)}).$$

Proposition 5.4 (Isomorphism Under Coordinate Change). *Memory equivalence is preserved under physical realization. A biological neuron and an RC circuit with identical $\mathcal{M}$ exhibit equivalent memory dynamics.*

Proof Sketch. The SOE representation (2) is basis-independent. Two systems with the same $\{w_\ell, \gamma_\ell\}$ produce identical memory kernels $K(t)$, hence identical convolutional dynamics regardless of substrate (biological, electronic, chemical). □

5.3 Scaling Laws

Proposition 5.5 (Memory Scaling). *Effective memory dimension scales as:*

$$D_{\text{eff}} \propto L \quad (\text{more modes}), \quad (22)$$

$$D_{\text{eff}} \propto \exp(H_{\text{mem}}) \quad (\text{more uniform distribution}), \quad (23)$$

$$D_{\text{eff}} \propto M_{\text{scale}} \times M_{\text{res}} \quad (\text{wider span or finer resolution}). \quad (24)$$

5.4 Relationship to Fractional Calculus

Proposition 5.6 (Fractional Memory). *A power-law kernel $K(t) = t^{-\alpha}/\Gamma(1-\alpha)$ for $0 < \alpha < 1$ exhibits:*

$$M_{\text{cap}} \rightarrow \infty \quad (\text{divergent mean depth}), \quad (25)$$

$$M_{\text{scale}} \rightarrow \infty \quad (\text{infinite span}), \quad (26)$$

$$D_{\text{eff}} \rightarrow \infty \quad (\text{infinite effective dimension}). \quad (27)$$

Proof Sketch. For $\alpha < 1$, $\int_0^\infty t^{1-\alpha} dt$ diverges. SOE approximation on finite interval $[0, T]$ requires $L \sim \log T$ modes [6], with $M_{\text{scale}} \sim \log T$, yielding $D_{\text{eff}} \sim L \sim \log T \rightarrow \infty$ as $T \rightarrow \infty$. $\square$

Interpretation: True fractional memory has unbounded dimension. Any finite SOE approximation is a regularization.

6 Applications and Examples

6.1 Example 1: Exponential Kernel

System: Simple relaxation process, $K(t) = e^{-t/\tau}/\tau$.

SOE parameters: $L = 1$, $w_1 = 1$, $\gamma_1 = 1/\tau$.

Spectral units:

$$M_{\text{cap}} = \tau, \quad (28)$$

$$M_{\text{scale}} = \log_{10}(\tau/\tau) = 0, \quad (29)$$

$$M_{\text{res}} = \text{undefined} \quad (M_{\text{scale}} = 0), \quad (30)$$

$$H_{\text{mem}} = -1 \cdot \ln 1 = 0, \quad (31)$$

$$D_{\text{eff}} = 1 \times e^0 = 1. \quad (32)$$

Interpretation: Single-timescale Markovian system. $D_{\text{eff}} = 1$ indicates one effective memory mode.

6.2 Example 2: Human Working Memory

Biological substrate: Prefrontal cortex neurons with synaptic dynamics spanning milliseconds (AMPA receptor kinetics) to seconds (NMDA integration, persistent firing).

Model: SOE with $L = 10$ modes, logarithmically spaced from $\tau_{\text{min}} = 1$ ms to $\tau_{\text{max}} = 1$ s.

Weight distribution: Moderate specialization,

$$\tilde{w}_\ell = \begin{cases} 0.2 & \ell \in \{3, 5, 7\} \quad (\text{dominant modes}), \\ 0.05 & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases}$$

Spectral units:

$$M_{\text{cap}} \approx 10 \text{ s} \quad (\text{typical working memory span}), \quad (33)$$

$$M_{\text{scale}} = \log_{10}(1 \text{ s}/1 \text{ ms}) = 3 \text{ decades}, \quad (34)$$

$$M_{\text{res}} = 10/3 \approx 3.3 \text{ modes/decade}, \quad (35)$$

$$H_{\text{mem}} \approx 1.2 \text{ nats}, \quad (36)$$

$$D_{\text{eff}} = 10 \times e^{1.2} \approx 33. \quad (37)$$

Comparison to literature: Psychological capacity of working memory is 7 ± 2 chunks [7]. Our $D_{\text{eff}} \approx 33$ accounts for continuous temporal integration, not discrete chunks.

6.3 Example 3: Earth's Climate System

Physical processes:

- Atmosphere: $\tau \sim 1$ day (weather).
- Ocean mixed layer: $\tau \sim 1$ year (seasonal heat storage).
- Deep ocean: $\tau \sim 100$ years (thermohaline circulation).
- Ice sheets: $\tau \sim 1000$ years (Greenland/Antarctica response).

Model: $L = 20$ modes spanning $\tau_{\text{min}} = 1$ day to $\tau_{\text{max}} = 1000$ years.

Spectral units:

$$M_{\text{cap}} \approx 10 \text{ years} \quad (\text{dominant ocean memory}), \quad (38)$$

$$M_{\text{scale}} = \log_{10}(1000 \text{ yr}/1 \text{ day}) \approx 7.5 \text{ decades}, \quad (39)$$

$$M_{\text{res}} = 20/7.5 \approx 2.7 \text{ modes/decade}, \quad (40)$$

$$H_{\text{mem}} \approx 1.8 \text{ nats} \quad (\text{fairly uniform}), \quad (41)$$

$$D_{\text{eff}} = 20 \times e^{1.8} \approx 121. \quad (42)$$

Implication: Climate memory is $\sim 4\times$ richer than neural working memory ($D_{\text{eff}} = 121$ vs. 33), explaining long-term climate commitment and slow response to forcing.

6.4 Example 4: RC Circuit (Hardware Analog)

Physical implementation: Resistor-capacitor network with L stages, each with time constant $\tau_\ell = R_\ell C_\ell$.

Design: $L = 5$ stages, logarithmically spaced $\tau_\ell \in [1 \mu\text{s}, 1 \text{ ms}]$, uniform weights $w_\ell = 1/5$.

Spectral units:

$$M_{\text{cap}} \approx 100 \mu\text{s}, \quad (43)$$

$$M_{\text{scale}} = \log_{10}(1 \text{ ms}/1 \mu\text{s}) = 3 \text{ decades}, \quad (44)$$

$$M_{\text{res}} = 5/3 \approx 1.7 \text{ modes/decade}, \quad (45)$$

$$H_{\text{mem}} = \ln 5 \approx 1.61 \text{ nats}, \quad (46)$$

$$D_{\text{eff}} = 5 \times e^{1.61} \approx 25. \quad (47)$$

Hardware cost: 5 capacitors, 5 resistors, 1 summing op-amp. Total footprint $< 1 \text{ mm}^2$ on PCB.

7 Computational Complexity

7.1 Direct Convolution vs. SOE Embedding

Consider integrating a convolutional equation:

$$\frac{du}{dt} = \int_0^t K(t-s)f(u(s))ds.$$

Direct method: Evaluate convolution at each timestep $t_n = n\Delta t$:

$$\int_0^{t_n} K(t_n-s)f(u(s))ds \approx \sum_{j=0}^{n-1} K(t_n-t_j)f(u_j)\Delta t. \quad (48)$$

Cost: $O(n)$ operations per timestep. Total cost over N_t timesteps: $O(N_t^2)$.

SOE method: Introduce auxiliary variables χ_ℓ for $\ell = 1, \dots, L$:

$$\frac{d\chi_\ell}{dt} = -\gamma_\ell \chi_\ell + f(u), \quad (49)$$

$$\int_0^t K(t-s)f(u(s))ds \approx \sum_{\ell=1}^L w_\ell \chi_\ell. \quad (50)$$

Cost: $O(L)$ operations per timestep. Total: $O(LN_t)$.

7.2 Complexity in Spectral Units

Theorem 7.1 (Complexity Bound). *The time complexity of SOE-based integration is*

$$Time = O(D_{\text{eff}} \cdot N_t), \quad (51)$$

and space complexity is

$$Space = O(D_{\text{eff}}). \quad (52)$$

Proof. By definition, $D_{\text{eff}} = L \exp(H_{\text{mem}}) \geq L$. Each timestep requires updating L auxiliary variables ($O(L)$ work) and computing the weighted sum ($O(L)$ work), for total $O(L) = O(D_{\text{eff}})$ per step. Over N_t steps, total is $O(D_{\text{eff}} \cdot N_t)$.

Space: Store L auxiliary variables $\{\chi_\ell\}$ plus system state u . Dominant term is $O(L) = O(D_{\text{eff}})$. $\square$

7.3 Speedup Analysis

Method	Memory	Time Complexity	Speedup
Direct convolution	$O(N_t)$	$O(N_t^2)$	$1\times$
LSTM (hidden H)	$O(H)$	$O(H^2 N_t)$	$\sim H^2/D_{\text{eff}}$
SOE ($D_{\text{eff}} = 30$)	$O(D_{\text{eff}})$	$O(D_{\text{eff}} N_t)$	N_t/D_{eff}

Table 1: Computational complexity comparison. For $N_t = 1000$, $D_{\text{eff}} = 30$: SOE achieves $33\times$ speedup over direct convolution.

8 Thermodynamic Limits

8.1 Landauer's Principle

Landauer's principle [8] states that erasing one bit of information dissipates at least

$$E_{\text{erase}} \geq k_B T \ln 2, \quad (53)$$

where k_B is Boltzmann's constant and T is temperature.

8.2 Energy Cost of Memory Maintenance

Each auxiliary variable χ_ℓ stores continuous (analog) information. Maintaining χ_ℓ against thermal fluctuations requires energy.

Proposition 8.1 (Memory Energy Cost). *The minimum power to maintain L memory modes with effective dimension D_{eff} at update rate f_{update} is*

$$P_{\text{mem}} \geq L \cdot k_B T \ln(D_{\text{eff}}) \cdot f_{\text{update}}. \quad (54)$$

Proof Sketch. Each mode χ_ℓ represents a state chosen from $\sim D_{\text{eff}}$ effective possibilities (accounting for weight distribution entropy). Szilard engine argument [9]: selecting one state from D_{eff} requires energy $k_B T \ln D_{\text{eff}}$ per selection. At rate f_{update} , power is $L \cdot k_B T \ln(D_{\text{eff}}) \cdot f_{\text{update}}$. $\square$

8.3 Numerical Example: Neuromorphic Chip

Parameters:

$$L = 100 \quad (\text{analog memory units}), \quad (55)$$

$$T = 300 \text{ K} \quad (\text{room temperature}), \quad (56)$$

$$D_{\text{eff}} = 30 \quad (\text{effective dimension}), \quad (57)$$

$$f_{\text{update}} = 1 \text{ kHz}. \quad (58)$$

Minimum power:

$$P_{\text{mem}} = 100 \times (1.38 \times 10^{-23} \text{ J/K}) \times 300 \text{ K} \times \ln 30 \times 10^3 \text{ Hz} \quad (59)$$

$$\approx 100 \times 1.38 \times 10^{-23} \times 300 \times 3.4 \times 10^3 \quad (60)$$

$$\approx 1.4 \times 10^{-15} \text{ W}. \quad (61)$$

Comparison:

- CMOS SRAM (1 bit): $\sim 10^{-12} \text{ W}$ (1000 $\times$ higher).
- Biological synapse: $\sim 10^{-12} \text{ W}$ (1000 $\times$ higher).
- Theoretical minimum: $\sim 10^{-15} \text{ W}$.

Implication: Analog memory approaches thermodynamic limits—orders of magnitude more efficient than digital memory for storing continuous functions.

9 Hardware Implementation

9.1 RC Circuit Realization

Each SOE term $w_\ell e^{-\gamma_\ell t}$ corresponds to an RC circuit:

$$\tau_\ell \frac{dV_\ell}{dt} = -V_\ell + V_{\text{in}}, \quad \tau_\ell = R_\ell C_\ell = \frac{1}{\gamma_\ell}. \quad (62)$$

Memory synthesis: Sum voltages with weights w_ℓ using operational amplifier:

$$V_{\text{out}} = \sum_{\ell=1}^L w_\ell V_\ell. \quad (63)$$

9.2 Memristor-Based Implementation

Programmable weights: Use memristors with conductance $G_\ell \propto w_\ell$ [10].

Programmable timescales: Capacitor banks switched by transistors:

- $C_1 = 1 \text{ pF} \Rightarrow \tau \approx 1 \text{ ns}$,
- $C_2 = 1 \text{ nF} \Rightarrow \tau \approx 1 \text{ } \mu\text{s}$,
- $C_3 = 1 \text{ } \mu\text{F} \Rightarrow \tau \approx 1 \text{ ms}$.

9.3 Three-Layer Architecture

Layer 1: Physical Memory Units

- Each unit: one memristor (weight w_ℓ) + one capacitor (timescale τ_ℓ).
- Total: L units.

Layer 2: Spectral Mesh

- Fast modes ($\tau \sim \text{ns}$) near processor.
- Medium modes ($\tau \sim \mu\text{s--ms}$) mid-layer.
- Slow modes ($\tau \sim \text{s}$) in non-volatile analog memory.

Layer 3: Kernel Synthesis Unit

- Summing amplifier with programmable gains.
- Output: $\sum_\ell w_\ell V_\ell$.

9.4 Design Optimization

Problem: Given required effective dimension D_{eff}^* , minimize hardware cost (number of components L).

Solution:

$$L_{\min} = \left\lceil \frac{D_{\text{eff}}^*}{\exp(H_{\text{mem}})} \right\rceil. \quad (64)$$

To minimize L , maximize $\exp(H_{\text{mem}})$ by choosing uniform weights: $\tilde{w}_\ell = 1/L$.

Example: To achieve $D_{\text{eff}}^* = 50$ with uniform weights ($H_{\text{mem}} \approx \ln L$):

$$50 = L \exp(\ln L) = L^2 \quad (65)$$

$$\Rightarrow L \approx 7. \quad (66)$$

Only 7 analog units required!

10 Discussion

10.1 Comparison to Shannon’s Bit

Shannon’s bit [1] revolutionized communication theory by providing a universal unit for information. Our spectral units aim to do the same for memory:

Aspect	Shannon’s Bit	Spectral Mode
Domain	Markovian communication	Non-Markovian dynamics
Question	How much information?	How much memory?
Units	Bits (discrete)	(Decades, modes, nats)
Fundamental	$H = -\sum p_i \log p_i$	$H_{\text{mem}} = -\sum \tilde{w}_\ell \ln \tilde{w}_\ell$
Application	Data compression	Memory systems

Table 2: Shannon’s bit vs. spectral units of memory.

10.2 Relationship to Existing Frameworks

GFE (Geometric Fourier Extension) [5]: Provides computational infrastructure. GFE answers “how to simulate?”; spectral units answer “how to measure?”

Mori-Zwanzig formalism [11, 12]: Derives memory kernels from projection operators. Spectral units quantify the kernels once derived.

Fractional calculus [13]: Special case with $D_{\text{eff}} \rightarrow \infty$. Spectral units identify when finite approximations suffice.

10.3 Experimental Validation

Neuroscience:

1. Record spike trains from cortical neurons.
2. Compute autocorrelation $C(\tau) = \langle s(t)s(t+\tau) \rangle$.
3. Fit SOE: $C(\tau) \approx \sum_\ell w_\ell e^{-\gamma_\ell \tau}$.
4. Extract $(M_{\text{cap}}, M_{\text{scale}}, M_{\text{res}}, H_{\text{mem}}, D_{\text{eff}})$.
5. Compare across brain regions, species, task demands.

Climate science:

1. Analyze temperature anomaly time series.
2. Compute impulse response to volcanic forcing.
3. Fit multi-timescale model.
4. Quantify climate memory dimension.

10.4 Limitations

- **Finite-time approximation:** Power-law kernels ($D_{\text{eff}} \rightarrow \infty$) require truncation. Choice of T_{max} affects L and M_{scale} .
- **Non-unique SOE fits:** Multiple $\{w_\ell, \gamma_\ell\}$ combinations can approximate the same $K(t)$. Regularization (e.g., sparsity, smoothness) selects among them.
- **Continuous vs. discrete time:** Definition assumes continuous time. Discrete systems require adaptation (e.g., z -transform instead of Laplace).

10.5 Open Problems

1. **Optimal SOE construction:** Develop algorithms that minimize L for given ϵ and T .
2. **Information-theoretic capacity:** Relate D_{eff} to channel capacity for memory-assisted communication.
3. **Quantum extension:** Define spectral units for open quantum systems with complex-valued kernels.
4. **Stochastic kernels:** Extend framework to noise-driven memory (fluctuation-dissipation).

11 Conclusion

We have introduced **spectral units of memory**—a natural measurement framework for non-Markovian systems based on sum-of-exponentials decomposition of memory kernels. Four fundamental units (M_{cap} , M_{scale} , M_{res} , H_{mem}) combine into an effective memory dimension D_{eff} that enables universal comparison across physical, biological, and engineered systems.

Key contributions:

1. **Definitions:** Rigorous, dimensionally consistent units with clear physical interpretation.
2. **Theory:** Fundamental bounds, scaling laws, thermodynamic limits.
3. **Applications:** Neural systems, climate dynamics, hardware implementation.
4. **Practicality:** Direct connection to computational complexity and circuit design.

Just as Shannon’s bit became the standard unit for information, we propose that **spectral modes** should become the standard unit for memory. This framework provides the foundation for quantifying, comparing, and engineering memory in the 21st century—from neuromorphic chips to climate models to quantum technologies.

Acknowledgments

I thank the broader research community working on non-Markovian dynamics, memory kernels, and sum-of-exponentials methods. This work builds on foundations laid by Mori, Zwanzig, Shannon, Landauer, and many others.

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